

KF23 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

We sometimes want to avoid the sad truth of KF Confession 5:

We attacked and cruelly suppressed our True Self and lost our true life.

The Self-Hate Massage

Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause)* Bring to mind an area of your life that stirs up chronic self-hate for you. Perhaps you cannot please others, or perhaps you cannot please yourself. Perhaps your limitations are interfering with the achievement of your dreams. You may be experiencing self-hate because you have begun to break out of your Idol’s pride system or, perhaps, because you are still stuck in it. If you cannot identify the cause of your self-hate, you might be able to focus on the symptoms. We will bring our hurt and fear into this meditation and get acquainted with it using our KF tools. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

CONSIDER

Take a moment to collect yourself within this present space. Feel the air and the clothing on your body. Notice any noises. What is going on inside your skin? *(Pause for 30 seconds)* Now, consider this area of self-hate. Notice the discomfort you feel when you think of it. Even though you hate this thing, allow it to rest inside your skin for one minute, without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

COMPASSION

As you breathe, experience yourself as a creature with limitations breathing in a material world. *(Pause)* You are not a god. *(Pause)* As you breathe in and out, imagine your area of self-hate moving in and out with the breath, massaging this place in your soul that is stuck or cramped. For one minute, give it and receive it with compassion. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

CLEANSE

Notice your entire body as it breathes. *(Pause)* Breathe with your mind, body, and soul as you open of the prison cells of your shame, regrets, hurt, and guilt. *(Pause)* Allow the clean air to sweep through those

dark, stagnant places for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

And pause.

Jesus sees our efforts and offers us the gift of an open door to more training and opportunities. He invites us to respond with the karis gift of allowing Him to train us and purify us so that we can enter into the joy of fulfilling our potential in karis relationship with Him.

Continue to breathe as you listen to my translation of Revelation 3:8.

⁸Jesus says, “I know your efforts. Look at what is in front of you! I grant to you this open door, a door that no one is able to shut—not even you. There is evidence that you do have a little strength, for you have guarded My way of doing things and have not rejected My character and authority in your life.”

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

Last week, we were reminded of how the Idol Self uses self-hate to lash us into performing according to the shoulds and claims of our legal systems—our personal law. The Idol is only motivated by law, and unlike the True Self, is not alive, so it cannot access the resources of God and the Creation. These resources can only be accessed through a karis relationship with God. In this stagnant state of disconnection, the Idol needs a power source—and what could be more natural than to tap into our instinct to survive and our innate fear of punishment and shame. If the Idol can scare us, it can control us.

All Idol types feel a compulsive need to terminate the tension that comes with making changes in their lives, and they terminate that tension by returning to old habitual patterns. Although each type experiences and releases their tension in different ways, the driving forces are the same. All types are driven by the fear of self-hate and the fear of their inability to fulfill their idealized dreams. My son once told me about a French novelist who described this compulsive need to silence these fears as the *rage to conclude*.¹ The rage to conclude is the discomfort we feel when we are enduring our craving to return to old habitual patterns. We want to conclude the tension of going into the not knowing, of changing course, and of taking responsibility for the quality of our own lives, so we give in to the compelling needs of our fear and pride.

Changing your life is similar to turning a car that is going at high speed. When you try to turn the car, it creates a lot of tension, both in the car and in you. You will need to slow down and exercise a great deal of skill and mindfulness to endure that tension and carefully maintain the car’s new direction. Without courage and endurance, you will conclude your tension by allowing the car to revert to its original speed and path. Similarly, when you begin to alter the direction of your life, you feel the tension of change and experience compelling emotions that invite you to conclude that tension by returning to your own status quo. Without training and development, you will simply engage the autopilot of the Idol’s system, let go of the wheel, and revert to the old misoriented behaviors that have produced unwanted outcomes in the past. Taking refuge in habitual behaviors and patterns is an easy way to conclude our tension. We become

like the unthinking horse that keeps going back to a noisome, unhealthy barn. Mindful endurance and courageous effort train us to resist that urge to return to old patterns; it helps us stand firm in the face of our rage to conclude. But your Idol Self will not let you defy its legal systems without a fight—and if you have not been training hard and developing strategies, you will lose the fight.

As you begin to turn toward your True Self, you will regularly feel uneasy and confused about what you should do. That's because you are disengaging from your Idol's autopilot, and your claims and shoulds are no longer in charge. The Idol Self won't give up easily, so you may have chaotic feelings and strong compulsions that you can't explain. Things may feel worse before they get better even though you are experiencing more stability in your life.

If you are a mastery type and seeking to recover your True Self, you will practice letting go of control and begin resisting the temptation to assert yourself; you will let go of forcing others to comply, to admire, or to meet your standards. You will learn to value understanding others more than being understood. You will come to recognize your own limitations. Even though you may long to be the hero, the punisher, or the Standards and Evaluations Officer, you will start admitting that you are often helpless and vulnerable. You will make an effort to honor other people's realities and will take responsibility for your own reality. You will learn to pause and shut up when you are frustrated, knowing that rage is a signal to do a worksheet. These are just a few areas where you might practice letting go. Of course, your Idol Self is not interested in becoming a humble beginner who needs to learn new skills, so every time you practice these skills, you will feel quite uncomfortable.

A mastery man continued in a relationship when he really felt like attacking and pushing away the other person. It took him a while to recognize that the person he wanted to reject was capable of hurting his pride, and that the powerful fear of hurt pride was making him particularly sensitive and hair-triggered around this person who, quite simply, did not support his search for glory. The mastery man courageously chose to continue in the relationship and, soon after, came to me wondering why he felt a constant sense of unease and anxiety. He found himself obsessing about the person. I helped him recognize that he was experiencing self-hate because he had allowed this person to continue in his life without punishing them or imposing his own superiority. It is a huge accomplishment for mastery types to hang in there while craving vindictive triumph and longing to assert themselves as the boss or the best. The tension of self-hate can drive mastery people to act in irrational and even destructive ways to restore their pride. When they refuse to conclude their frustrations by grabbing power or asserting their superiority and self-righteousness, they have to endure excruciating tension.

Mastery types have a difficult time attending Karis Fellowships. Showing up regularly means that they need help, have messed up, and can't figure it all out in a week. Oh, the multitude of horrors they endure! They are even asked to reveal to others their weaknesses and failures! Mastery types crave opportunities to display their superiority; KF, however, invites them to practice humility. Rather than examine the quality of their choices and behavior, they prefer to spend their time asserting themselves in activities that satisfy their pride system. They want to believe that knowing is the same as being and that the illusion of effortless superiority, based on their own evaluation of themselves, is enough to achieve orientation. Mastery types seek to gloriously commandeer the powerful life that is the goal of our KF training. They cannot understand that such a life cannot be gained through willpower or by accumulating information. This higher quality of life is achieved gradually and organically as we continue to develop our True Self—and mastery types find the process exasperating.

A self-effacing woman believes that she is gifted in nurturing and caring for others. Her identity has

become centered around helping others, and her virtue story is that she has the gift of mercy. She prefers fantasies to realities. She wants to be able to magically heal people without making any effort to develop her character. She spends a great deal of her time and money attending church services and conferences where emotion is considered evidence of spirituality. In her mind, these experiences indicate an extraordinary connection to God. She hopes that by participating she will be divinely zapped with the power to heal other people. Her lack of development makes her vulnerable to liars because she wants to believe the best about everyone. She does what is easy for herself and expects others to appreciate what she offers. Her constant hope is to be instantly and effortlessly connected with people and to bask in their appreciation. This gives her an illusion of self-value. She wants to find a partner who will do the expansive work that is taboo for her so that she can borrow self-esteem from his achievements. She can then avoid the laborious and painful struggle required to discover her own potential and fulfill her True Self and her mission. Self-effacing people need to make a huge effort if they are serious about exploring their potential. They generate more suffering for themselves than the other types because suffering supports their idealized dreams of helplessness. Just thinking about their potential and the possibility of self-expansion stirs up self-hate. They do not know how to fight well, and fighting self-hate is a grim, desperate battle. Self-effacing types will conclude their rage, or tension, by sacrificing themselves and their resources, tormenting themselves with negative feelings, and losing themselves in someone or something else.

Self-effacing people love KF when they first join, but eventually they are confronted with the reality that they must give up their dreams of finding fulfillment through others and take up the very frightening work of investing in their own True Self. If their mission involves anything but self-sacrifice and connecting to others, they feel terrified. Investing in others gives them a sense of value. They need to find their value through others because they don't value themselves. Whenever they invest in themselves, they suffer the painful backlash of the Idol's vicious judgment. They often externalize this inner experience and believe that the judgment is coming from other people or organizations—even from Karis Fellowships. They unconsciously goad others into attacking or despising them in order to maintain their role as martyrs and victims. Giving up their role as a self-sacrificing victim would mean giving up their identity.

Resigned people feel uneasy or even anxious about any situation that might reveal their need to change, cooperate, or contribute. They conclude their tension and calm their anxiety by restricting their thinking, feelings, and experiences. They are very adept at stonewalling or excusing themselves with stories that confuse, fatigue, or irritate both themselves and others. It is a huge accomplishment for a resigned person to endure the effort and bother of change and suffer the pain of the associated and unpredictable struggles.

A resigned KF woman was trying to break out of her old patterns, but the linebacker of self-hate was waiting for her. When she put herself in a professional situation, she was forced to connect with the realities of the marketplace. She lacked certain social and personal skills, but this wasn't what actually interfered with her professional life. Her self-hate urged her to sabotage her own efforts by damaging other people's property, losing things that people needed, feeling depressed, and dropping responsibilities, which caused stress for others. She even unconsciously attacked her own body. She desperately wanted to conclude the tension of her situation by quitting her job and returning to her old inert habits. Her terror of exploring her potential and experiencing real change made it difficult for her to recognize all the progress she had achieved since joining KF.

Resigned people sometimes leave Karis Fellowships when they begin to thaw out and start experiencing uncomfortable emotions. They feel anxiety when they realize that they cannot continue to drift but need to grow up and take responsibility for the quality of their lives; they need to circulate and offer something

in this world. If they become aware that they need to change, or if they see evidence of real change, they often stop filling out and sharing their **Meeting Preparation Guides**. They don't want to deal with real evidence or have any record of beneficial change in their lives. It is inexpressibly difficult for resigned types to work on themselves because they find change terrifying; even the thought of a worksheet or a tap is excruciating. The obvious way to conclude this tension is to quit.

When we are in self-hate, we feel a rage to conclude, or put an end to, our discomfort. That rage, or overwhelming passion to resolve our feelings, drives us back into old patterns and habits. Self-discipline and just saying no will not strengthen our ability to endure the tension, and the battle often ends in defeat and more debilitating discouragement. We cannot fight easy on just willpower; we need to use our tools to tackle the Idol and come to know the real enemy. The real enemy is not our self-hate. It is not others or life. It is the Idol Self, its pride system, and its search for glory.

Mindfulness skills help us step back from the feelings and stories that the Idol generates. Self-hate can be a signal that the True Self is getting stronger. It is not a signal to quit. With the help of KF training, we can stand and observe—and also rejoice, knowing that our discomfort is an indication that we are strong enough to engage in battle with the Idol. By training hard, we can fight easy. Training keeps us fit; the fight keeps us wary and skilled. Through training and skillful fighting, we build lives of increasing freedom and self-confidence, and we become a walking revelation of the glory of God.

In KF lesson 25, we will learn another powerful tool for calming the rage to conclude. It is called the **T-A-T**, or the **Tapas Acupressure Technique**.² If you want to start exploring the **T-A-T**, you can find instructions on the Karis Fellowships website under the **Toolbox** tab, or you can search for TAT at [Alison's tapping and TAT videos](#).

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, in my rage to conclude remind me to hold my course toward You. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

In this lesson, we will look at some familiar verses from the Gospel of John that give us insight into the mechanism of self-hate. These verses also encourage us to continually present ourselves to the light of examination in the courtroom of our soul so that we can learn how to cooperate with God and fulfill our business. Our business is to deal with our fear, reorient to our true glory, and reveal the divine nature that God has given to us, His creatures.

Let's now read **John 3:16–21** in my paraphrase. In the preceding verses, Jesus has been talking to Nicodemus about being born again. Poor Nicodemus seems to be feeling some self-hate, and Jesus addresses those feelings.

¹⁶God loved this sick world so much that He gave to the world the only child of His nature, His Son, so that everyone who trusts Him with their lives shall not be ruined or destroyed

but live an eternal life. ¹⁷Let me explain. God did not send His Son into this sick world to decide against the world; God sent His Son so that the world might be rescued through Him. ¹⁸There is no judgment against a person who trusts the Son, but those who do not trust Him are already decided against. They are becoming ruined and destroyed because they have not trusted in the character and authority of the only Son of God. ¹⁹And this is that judgment: the light has come into this sick world, and people, out of their own character and choice, loved the darkness rather than the light because their beliefs and actions were misoriented, causing pain and trouble for everyone. ²⁰For those who do worthless things hate the light and do not come to the light because they fear that their deeds will be shown to be what they actually are—worthless and producing nothing of real value. ²¹But the one who is a doer of the truth comes to more and more light so that his or her deeds may be revealed for what they are—the result of hard work and the fulfillment of their own business in God.

Take a deep breath.

Although John often uses the word judgment in this passage, it is evident that God isn't judging anyone. Quite the contrary! It is we who are judging ourselves. When we studied *Neurosis and Human Growth* together, we felt exposed. The book shone a light on our illusions and pride, and we may have experienced some symptoms of self-hate, like feeling bored or overwhelmed, or perhaps angry or dismayed. In the same way, when we read about the life of Jesus or compare our choices to those of an oriented person, we judge ourselves and may feel some shame. In the light of oriented understanding, this reaction is quite natural, but we take it a step further—we condemn ourselves. We compare our own misoriented choices to what we now recognize as oriented and healthy, and we find ourselves wanting, or falling short. We might then judge self-examination as bad, reject it, and even hate it. Or we might run away because we simply prefer to go on as we are. So, we see in this passage that self-judgment is really the result of a kind of exposure; we are exposed to light that shows us who we actually are—and we don't like it.

When we start to approach the light of exposure, we can feel quite uncomfortable, sorrowful, angry, or even numb. We begin to see the worthlessness of choosing a neurotic path to gain a sense of value, and we recognize that we have poured a huge amount of resources into efforts that achieved nothing of real value. It is grievous, and we can feel remorse. Our neurotic development has damaged our True Self and the True Self of others, and we have obstructed God's purposes in this world. We can accept that truth without hating ourselves, because God has provided an advocate in Jesus. Our misoriented choices are no surprise to Him. We most likely came to the light as soon as we were ready to do so, and if we needed to wander in worthlessness for a time before entering the light, we can be thankful that our wanderings helped us get here. Those neurotic efforts were not so worthless after all. You can have confidence that, given the table that was set before you, you came to this place of healing as soon as you could. You are far ahead of the vast majority of people who never get here at all.

So, what is John saying here about judgment? Let's look at this passage in terms of our KF purpose, which is to restore the True Self. As I learn to trust Jesus, I experience His gracious character and stop judging myself. I am able to rest in His authority as the only Righteous Judge because I know that He is not judging me. I acknowledge that I am His creature. I understand that my business is to allow myself to be rescued and to cooperate with Him as, together, we restore my True Self. God has declared me to be safe from condemnation, so it is not my business to heap self-hate on myself.³ The more that I understand His authority and my business, the more vision and courage I have to take the Believe It Path instead of

judging myself or others. I know that Jesus is the Great Shepherd who will guide me back to my True Self if I cooperate with Him.

If you do not believe or trust Jesus, you cannot cooperate with Him because, frankly, you are too afraid to do so. You yourself are the only god that you recognize. In your mind, you alone have the authority to judge, and you judge everything, including yourself, according to the standards imposed by your Idol. As a result, you live in a state of constant self-judgment and self-hate. When you are not trusting Jesus, you are trapped in the black box of your pride system. Your mind is attached to what is illusion and what *should* be rather than open to what is real and what *could* be. You prefer the darkness of your cherished illusions and rebelliously choose to avoid the light because you do not want the truth about your misorientation to be exposed.

In our efforts to excuse our misoriented behavior, we organize sin in a hierarchy of badness. Evaluating degrees of badness supports pride and avoids the truth about how damaging our brand of misorientation is. The truth is, no one gets away with anything. All misorientation hurts. The word *evil* seems worse than the word *harm* in our language, but in Greek these two words are the same. I prefer to use the terms *misoriented* and *misorientation* rather than words like *sin*, *bad*, *harmful*, or *evil* because I am trying to convey a state of general disharmony with God and the Creation rather than implying a hierarchy of badness. The reality is that all misorientation is bad; it is harmful to our glory, to the Creation, and to God's purposes. Whenever we choose misorientation, we fall short of the glory of God.

With Jesus as our Advocate in the courtroom of our soul, we have the courage to step into the light and allow our misorientation to be revealed and healed—and as we dare to reveal more and more of who we are, we discover more and more of who He is.⁴

In Karis Fellowships, we have chosen to come to the light in order to have the truth about our deeds revealed. Those deeds may be far from oriented, but what we do with our deeds is quite remarkable and unique: we bring our deeds to the light so that, together with Jesus, we can examine them and find healing. We are no longer living on autopilot, compulsively running away from the light and seeking the comfort and oblivion of darkness. This is a gigantic step forward. In the light, we examine our choices and desires and ask ourselves, “Is this the outcome I want?” If the outcome is not what we want, we set about exploring our healing and begin training hard. We learn to stop repeating the misoriented patterns of the past, and we build new patterns of thought and action that will produce oriented outcomes for our future.

When you are in self-hate about some deed, choice, or some kind of limitation, remember to appreciate the efforts you have made to grow and to change. Your efforts are of extraordinary value for they declare to the whole world the hope of the Gospel—the hope that we can grow and change, that we are not stuck, that we are not slaves. Growth means that we are alive, and anything that is truly alive reveals and declares the glory of God.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, kindly lead me to the light so that I might be truly alive. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some clean water and prepare to take some notes. *(Pause)* Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider allowing Jesus to reveal your deeds for what they truly are. (Repeat)* Keep in mind that Jesus does not seek to judge you but to rescue and commend you. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider allowing Jesus to reveal your deeds for what they truly are*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* Just observe your feelings, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Hold your experience in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush feelings or thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us and stretch us. Gently observe whatever you may be experiencing as you *consider allowing Jesus to reveal your deeds for what they truly are. (Pause)* Give yourself permission now to explore your thoughts and feelings without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider allowing Jesus to reveal your deeds for what they truly are*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what relief or dismay, or perhaps anxiety or curiosity, feels like in your body. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider allowing Him to reveal your deeds for what they truly are*. Are you comfortable, uncomfortable, or do you feel numb? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you judge the exposure of your deeds as good or evil? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something? Do you hope for something? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat to yourself the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity of an open door inviting you to explore your deeds.
- Welcome the light of the Holy Spirit, who leads you into all truth.⁵
- Welcome the reality of where you are right now and how far you have come.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁶

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As my deeds are revealed, I let go of the craving for power and control.
- As my deeds are revealed, I let go of the craving for esteem and affection.
- As my deeds are revealed, I let go of the craving for survival and comfort.
- As my deeds are revealed, I let go of the craving to change my situation. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time of training and healing together. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to the light and to the truth about who You created us to be. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design, with our community and the rest of Creation, with our mission, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ Gustave Flaubert, *Correspondence* (Paris 1929), volume 5, 111: “The rage for wanting to conclude is one of the most deadly and most fruitless manias to befall humanity.” Taken from *Beautiful Evidence*, Edward Tufte, Graphics Press LLC, 2006.

² en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tapas_Acupressure_Technique.

³ Rom. 8:1.

⁴ 1 John 2:1.

⁵ John 16:13.

⁶ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.